



the finals in Australia after holding its nerve to beat higher-ranked Thailand 2-1 in a do-or-die contest. Meanwhile, across the border, Bangladesh also broke new ground as it qualified for the Women's Asian Cup for the very first time.

Despite missing some of its most experienced players — like all-time top-scorer Sabina Khatun, who left the side in protest against English coach Peter Butler — Bangladesh managed to maintain a perfect record in the qualifiers.

With a squad of youngsters, the Bengal Tigresses opened their campaign with a 7-0 win against Bahrain before edging past better-ranked Myanmar 2-1 in a decisive battle that essentially sealed qualification. Bangladesh rounded off its campaign with another 7-0 drubbing, this time of Turkmenistan, to earn its place in the continental tournament.

Another notable qualifier was Uzbekistan, which marked its return

to the premier tournament after last playing in 2003. Uzbekistan guaranteed a place at the expense of Nepal, which it beat on penalties in their deciding clash after it ended 3-3 in regulation time.

Nepal's hat-trick hero Sabitra Bhandari and goalkeeper Anjana Rana Magar missed from the spot as Nepal continued its wait since 1999 to play in the Asian Cup.

The result marks a successful year for football in Uzbekistan, as in June, the men's team qualified for the FIFA World Cup for the first time in its history. It will be part of the 48-team tournament to be held in the USA, Canada and Mexico next year.

A dash of magic

Inter Miami's Lionel Messi seemed to have taken his side's 4-0 loss against Paris Saint-Germain in the FIFA Club World Cup 2025 as fuel to perform better, as he bagged six goals in three games on his return to Major League Soccer.

Fiery form: Inter Miami's Lionel Messi has taken his tally to 16 goals from 16 appearances in MLS this season, tied with Nashville's Sam Surridge in the Golden Boot race. GETTY IMAGES

The 38-year-old bagged a brace against CF Montreal, New England Revolution and Nashville SC since the start of July, making it five MLS games in a row in which he has scored two or more goals — a feat never previously achieved in the league.

He has taken his tally to 16 goals from 16 appearances in the league this season, tied with Nashville's Sam Surridge in the Golden Boot race.

Despite playing three games fewer than Eastern Conference leader Philadelphia Union, Inter Miami is fifth in the standings, just five points behind, and can top the table if it manages to win at least two of its games in hand.

Results updated as of July 14.